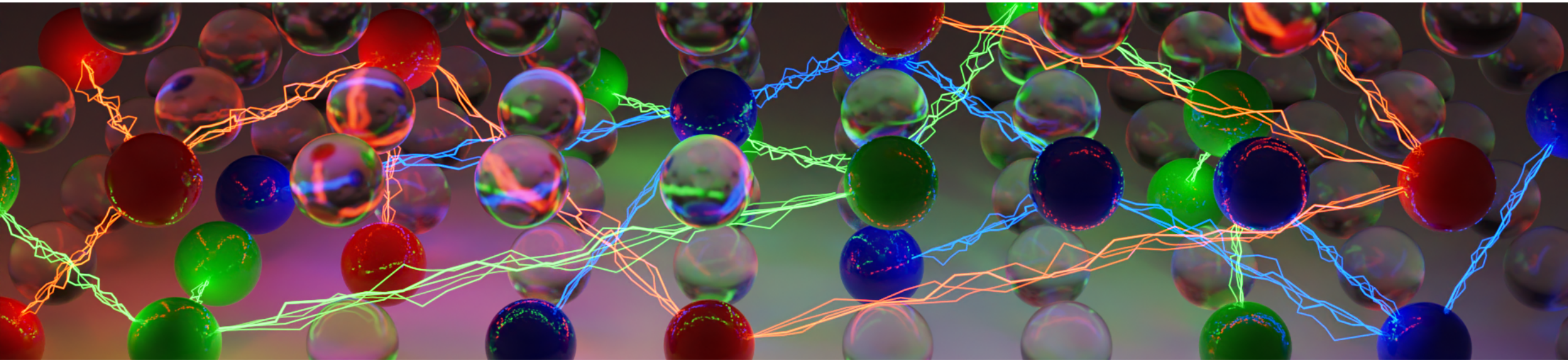
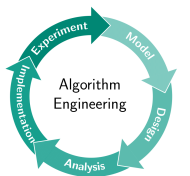




Practical SAT Solving

Lecture 12 – Satisfiability Modulo Theories (SMT)

Markus Iser, Dominik Schreiber | July 21, 2025



SAtRes
Scalable Automated Reasoning

Roadmap

- SMT: Motivation and definition
- Some example theories
- Formal framework and decidability
- SMT solving
 - Lazy approach: DPLL(T)
 - Eager approach: The case of Bit Vectors
- (Brief) pragmatics of SMT

Note: This lecture is mostly based on the following slide sets:

<https://github.com/biotomas/sat-lecture-kit/blob/main/slides/l10.tex>

(motivation, example theories, decidability, DPLL(T) example, bit vectors)

https://resources.mpi-inf.mpg.de/departments/rg1/conferences/vtsa08/slides/barret2_smt.pdf

(formal definitions)

<https://alexeyignatiev.github.io/ssa-school-2019/slides/ao-satsmtar19-slides.pdf>

(lazy vs. eager, DPLL(T) techniques & properties)

SMT: Motivation

Propositional logic: very low-level for many practical problems

- Linear (integer or real) arithmetic:

$$x + y < 5 \wedge (2x - y > 4 \vee x + y > 7)$$

- Non-linear arithmetic:

$$x^2 + y^2 = 4 \wedge x - y = 3$$

- Arithmetic as actually done by a computer:

$$4294967295 + 1 = 0$$

Natural point of extension: **First Order Logic** with suitable interpretation / semantics

What is SMT?

Satisfiability Modulo Theories (SMT)

Decide the satisfiability of a **First Order Logic (FOL)** formula with respect to a certain **background theory**.

■ **Syntax:** in most cases, **quantifier-free, ground fragment of FOL**

- Set of atomic **constants**
- Set of k -ary **functions** $f(x_1, \dots, x_k)$ ($k \geq 1$)
 - each x_i is a **term**, i.e., either a constant or some k' -ary function
- Set of k -ary **propositions** $P(x_1, \dots, x_k)$
 - $k = 0$: **Atom** as in propositional logic
 - each x_i is a term
- **Formula:** Boolean expression featuring the above propositions as its “variables”

e.g., 0, 1, null
e.g., +, $\times$, read, write

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■ **Semantics:** depends on chosen background theory

- Many theories feature equality, i.e., a special proposition $P_=(x, y) \Leftrightarrow x = y$
- Each theory adds some set of axioms that must hold

Theory: Equality with Uninterpreted Functions (EUF)

- Equality proposition “=” comes with some implicit axioms:

1. Reflexivity: $\forall x : x = x$

2. Symmetry: $\forall x \forall y : x = y \rightarrow y = x$

3. Transitivity: $\forall x \forall y \forall z : x = y \wedge y = z \rightarrow x = z$

4. Congruence: $\forall k \forall f(x_1, \dots, x_k) \forall x_1, \dots, x_k \forall y_1, \dots, y_k :$
 $\bigwedge_{i=1}^k x_i = y_i \rightarrow f(x_1, \dots, x_k) = f(y_1, \dots, y_k)$

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- Examples:

$$(z \neq x) \wedge (z \neq y)$$

$$h(a, g(f(b), f(c))) = d \wedge h(b, g(f(a), f(c))) \neq d \wedge a = b$$

Satisfiable for ≥ 3 objects

Unsatisfiable

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Unsatisfiable

- Useful to **abstract away** non-supported constructions / operations
- Also called **Theory of Equality**

Theory: Presburger Arithmetic

Arithmetic over natural numbers with addition only

- Constants: $0, 1$ · Functions: $+$ · Predicates: $=$
- Axioms:
 1. EUF axioms
 2. Null: $\forall x : x + 1 \neq 0$
 3. Successor: $\forall x, y : x + 1 = y + 1 \rightarrow x = y$
 4. Induction: $P(0) \wedge (\forall x : P(x) \rightarrow P(x + 1)) \rightarrow (\forall x : P(x))$
 5. Plus Zero: $\forall x : x + 0 = x$
 6. Plus successor: $\forall x, y : x + (y + 1) = (x + y) + 1$

Theory: Peano Arithmetic

Arithmetic over natural numbers with addition and multiplication

■ Constants: 0, 1 · Functions: +, × · Predicates: =

■ Axioms:

1. EUF axioms

2. Null: $\forall x : x + 1 \neq 0$

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5. Plus Zero: $\forall x : x + 0 = x$

6. Plus successor: $\forall x, y : x + (y + 1) = (x + y) + 1$

7. Times Zero: $\forall x : x \times 0 = 0$

8. Times successor: $\forall x, y : x \times (y + 1) = (x \times y) + x$

Theory: Arrays

Basic reasoning over arrays (and memory in general)

- Functions: $\text{read}(a, i), \text{write}(a, i, v)$ · Predicates: $=$
- Axioms:
 1. EUF axioms
 2. Read over write #1: $\forall a, v, i, j: i = j \rightarrow \text{read}(\text{write}(a, i, v), j) = v$
 2. Read over write #2: $\forall a, v, i, j: i \neq j \rightarrow \text{read}(\text{write}(a, i, v), j) = \text{read}(a, j)$
 3. Extensionality: $\forall a, b: a = b \leftrightarrow (\forall i: \text{read}(a, i) = \text{read}(b, i))$

SMT Definitions (semi-formal)

Signatures and Models

A **signature** Σ is a set of constants, functions, and predicates.

A **model** M of Σ is a pair of a set D , called the **domain** of M , and a mapping

- from each constant $c \in \Sigma$ to some $d \in D$;
- from each k -ary function $f \in \Sigma$ to some function $\phi : D^k \rightarrow D$; and
- from each k -ary predicate $P \in \Sigma$ to some *relation* $\mathcal{P} \subseteq D^k$.

Σ -formula, Σ -theories

A **Σ -formula** is a FOL formula over the according symbols of Σ .

A **Σ -theory** $\mathcal{T}$ is a set of sentences, each of which is a Σ -formula.

$\mathcal{T}$ -Satisfiability and $\mathcal{T}$ -Validity

A Σ -formula F is **$\mathcal{T}$ -satisfiable** iff there is a model M of $\mathcal{T}$ such that $\mathcal{T} \cup \{F\}$ is true under M .

A Σ -formula F is **$\mathcal{T}$ -valid** iff $\mathcal{T} \cup \{F\}$ is true under *all* models M of $\mathcal{T}$.

Decidability of SMT

Definition: Theory Decidability

A theory $\mathcal{T}$ is **decidable** if and only if the $\mathcal{T}$ -satisfiability of every Σ -formula is decidable.

Theory	Decidable?	Quantor-free Fragment decidable?	Conjunction of literals decidable?
Uninterpreted Functions	—	✓	✓
Peano Arithmetic	—	—	✓
Presburger Arithmetic	✓	✓	✓
Arrays	—	✓	✓

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- **Eager approach:** Find a **direct translation** of $\mathcal{T} \cup F$ to propositional logic; perform **SAT solving** [1]
 - Promising for “**Boolean theories**” like arrays, bit vectors
 - Need to encode **full theory in advance**
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- **Lazy approach:** Perform propositional reasoning over the **Boolean skeleton** of F ; lazily check whether a found propositional model is **consistent with $\mathcal{T}$** .
 - Known as **DPLL($\mathcal{T}$)** in literature [3]
 - Numerous optimizations lead to **close interaction** between SAT solver and theory solver
 - **Modular and flexible architecture**

Lazy Approach: Example

Σ -Formula F (linear integer arithmetic):

$$y \geq 1 \wedge (x < 0 \vee y < 1) \wedge (x \geq 0 \vee y < 0)$$

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Exclude this inconsistency:

$$\neg(y \geq 1) \vee \neg(y < 1)$$

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Exclude this inconsistency:

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Next Boolean skeleton:

$$A \wedge (B \vee C) \wedge (D \vee E) \wedge (\neg A \vee \neg C)$$

...

Lazy Approach

Optimizations of DPLL(T):

- Already check theory consistency of a **partial assignment** as it is being constructed
- Let theory solver **guide search** by returning **consequences** implied by a partial assignment
- Upon inconsistency, instead of a full restart, **backtrack** to a point where the assignment was still consistent

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DPLL(T) follows **modular approach**:

- SAT solver and theory solver communicate via relatively simple API
 - most recently, **IPASIR-UP** (“User Propagators”) [2]
- Theory solver only receives **conjunctions of literals**
 - Satisfiability of such conjunctions is **decidable in most theories**
- New theory? → just plug in a new theory solver
- SAT solver can be embedded with little effort

Bit Vectors via Eager Approach: Motivation

```
int x, y;  
...  
if (x - y > 0) {  
    assert(x > y);  
    ...  
}
```

Can this assertion fail?

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- Linear Integer Arithmetic: $x - y > 0 \wedge \neg(x > y)$ is unsatisfiable.

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if (x - y > 0) {  
    assert(x > y);  
    ...  
}
```

Can this assertion fail?

- Linear Integer Arithmetic: $x - y > 0 \wedge \neg(x > y)$ is unsatisfiable.
- Computer: **assertion fails** if $x = 2147483648$ and $y = 1$!

Bit Vector via Eager Approach: Theory (informal)

Bit Vector (BV) theory: Express numeric variables as **bit vectors**. Reason over them.

- Bit vector v has **bits** $v_0, \dots, v_{n-1}$, **(bit) length** $n = |v|$, **(unsigned) value** $\langle v \rangle = \sum_{i=0}^{|v|-1} 2^i v_i$
- **Positional manipulation functions**, like $\text{concat}(a, b) := (a_0, \dots, a_{n_a-1}, b_0, \dots, b_{n_b-1})$,
 $\text{zero_extend}(a, k) := (a_0, \dots, a_{n-1}, 0, \dots, 0)$ (k zeroes),
 $\text{leftshift}(a, k)$, $\text{rightshift}(a, k)$, etc.
- **Bitwise operation functions**, like $\text{not}(a)$, $\text{and}(a, b)$, $\text{or}(a, b)$, $\text{xor}(a, b)$
- **Arithmetic operation functions**, like $\text{add}(a, b)$, $\text{sub}(a, b)$, $\text{mul}(a, b)$
- **Comparison predicates**, like $=$, $<_{\text{signed}}$, $<_{\text{unsigned}}$, etc.

Above assertion example: $(0_{(32)} <_{\text{signed}} \text{sub}(x, y)) \wedge (x \leq_{\text{signed}} y)$

SMT solver for BV theory?

— eager approach is natural due to **intrinsically Boolean structure**

Bit Vector via Eager Theory: Encoding

Propositional encoding F of a bit vector formula ϕ :

- Initialize F as the **Boolean skeleton** of ϕ ,
substituting each predicate P with a Boolean **abstraction variable** $AV(P)$
- For each added abstraction variable $AV(P)$, extend F by **two kinds of constraints**:
 - constraints that express the **predicate** P
 - constraints for **each term in** P
(using n Boolean variables $v_0, \dots, v_{n-1}$ for each term corresponding to a bit vector v of length n)

Some (simple) examples for constraints:

$$AV(x = y) \leftrightarrow \left(\bigwedge_{i=0}^{|x|-1} x_i \leftrightarrow y_i \right)$$

$$AV(\text{and}(a, b)) \leftrightarrow \left(\bigwedge_{i=0}^{|x|-1} \text{and}(a, b)_i \leftrightarrow (a_i \wedge b_i) \right)$$

Bit Vector via Eager Theory: Remarks

- Some constraints may require **case distinction over bit vector values**
- Some constraints are **expensive** to encode
- **Incremental schemes** possible to save encoding effort
 - Under- or over-approximate encoding, react based on SAT/UNSAT
 - Add constraints lazily – **counter-example guided abstraction refinement (CEGAR)**
 - Approximate expensive operations (like $\text{mul}(a, b)$) by replacing them with **uninterpreted functions**
- Further reading: [4]

SMT in Practice

Example: Swap two integers without third variable

```
int x, y, oldx, oldy;  
...  
oldx = x;  
oldy = y;  
x = x + y;  
y = x - y;  
x = x - y;  
assert(y == oldx && x == oldy);
```

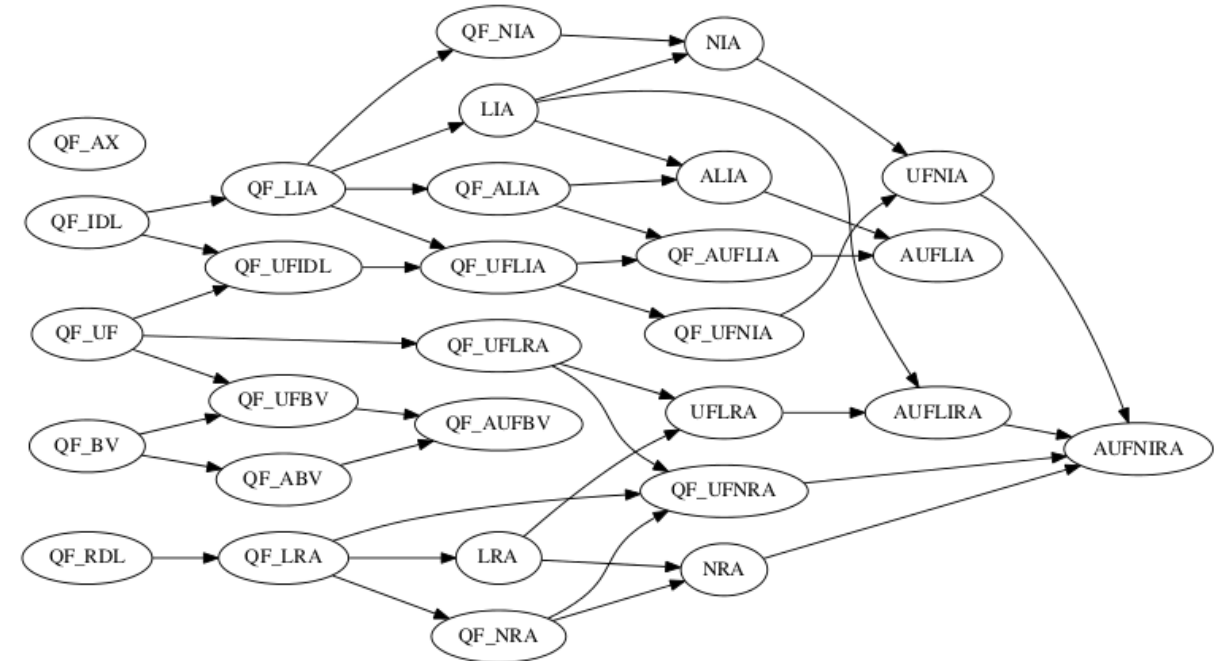
Example from <https://smt-lib.org/examples.shtml>

```
(set-logic QF_BV)  
(set-option :produce-models true)  
  
(declare-const x_0 (_ BitVec 32))  
(declare-const x_1 (_ BitVec 32))  
(declare-const x_2 (_ BitVec 32))  
(declare-const y_0 (_ BitVec 32))  
(declare-const y_1 (_ BitVec 32))  
(assert (= x_1 (bvadd x_0 y_0)))  
(assert (= y_1 (bvsub x_1 y_0)))  
(assert (= x_2 (bvsub x_1 y_1)))  
  
(assert (not  
  (and (= x_2 y_0)  
        (= y_1 x_0))))  
(check-sat)  
; unsat  
(exit)
```

SMT: Concluding Remarks

SMT is a vast area – we barely scratched the surface.

- Standardization of different theories & logics and their interactions
- SMT solvers support subsets of theories
 - Completely different reasoning needed for different theories, applications
- Increasingly relevant research topic: Proofs for SMT solvers
- Definitive resource surrounding SMT: <http://smt-lib.org/>



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- [1] Robert Brummayer und Armin Biere. „Boolector: An efficient SMT solver for bit-vectors and arrays“. In: *International Conference on Tools and Algorithms for the Construction and Analysis of Systems*. Springer. 2009, S. 174–177.
- [2] Katalin Fazekas u. a. „IPASIR-UP: User Propagators for CDCL“. In: *Theory and Applications of Satisfiability Testing (SAT)*. 2023. DOI: [10.4230/LIPIcs.SAT.2023.8](https://doi.org/10.4230/LIPIcs.SAT.2023.8).
- [3] Robert Nieuwenhuis, Albert Oliveras und Cesare Tinelli. „Solving SAT and SAT modulo theories: From an abstract Davis–Putnam–Logemann–Loveland procedure to DPLL(T)“. In: *Journal of the ACM (JACM)* 53.6 (2006), S. 937–977.
- [4] Samuel Teuber, Marko Kleine Büning und Carsten Sinz. „An Incremental Abstraction Scheme for Solving Hard SMT-Instances over Bit-Vectors“. In: *arXiv preprint arXiv:2008.10061* (2020).